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Political Science - 390: Political Data Visualization

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Evolution of Campaign Practices in Presidential Elections

Introduction:

November 7, 2000, Election Night.

Americans turned to their TV screens as news outlets covered the presidential election results across the country. Viewers at home watched as their votes determined their country's leader, continuing into the new millennium. State by state, candidates Al Gore and George W Bush went back and forth collecting electoral votes. The expectation was for voters to end the night with a clear idea of who would become the 43rd president. However, the public would not have a decision until roughly two months later, in what is now remembered as one of the closest elections in recent history.

Fast forward to the general presidential election of 2008, Illinois Senator Barack Obama would win in a convincing fashion against Arizona Senator and Vietnam War hero, John McCain. From 2000 to 2008, the transition from a closely contested race to a comfortable victory can be attributed to changes in election culture and campaign practices. In this paper, I will use data visualizations to portray these advancements and how they've influenced presidential elections.

Revisiting 2000:

It is often remembered that in 2000, Democratic candidate Al Gore won the popular vote but lost the Electoral College by 5 votes to Republican candidate George W. Bush. With 17 swing states in this election, the deciding state was Florida, where the less than 1,800-vote difference required rounds of machine and manual recounts as demanded by Gore. With time constraints and the absence of a future president, the legitimacy of these recounts reached the Supreme Court, where it ruled in favor of Bush, making him the 43rd president of the United States.

Below is a map showing voter margins at the county level in Florida, highlighting areas—specifically central Florida—with extremely close margins, reflecting the tight race overall.

2000 Election By Counties in Florida

Margin: $(\text{Gore votes} - \text{Bush votes}) / (\text{Gore votes} + \text{Bush votes})$

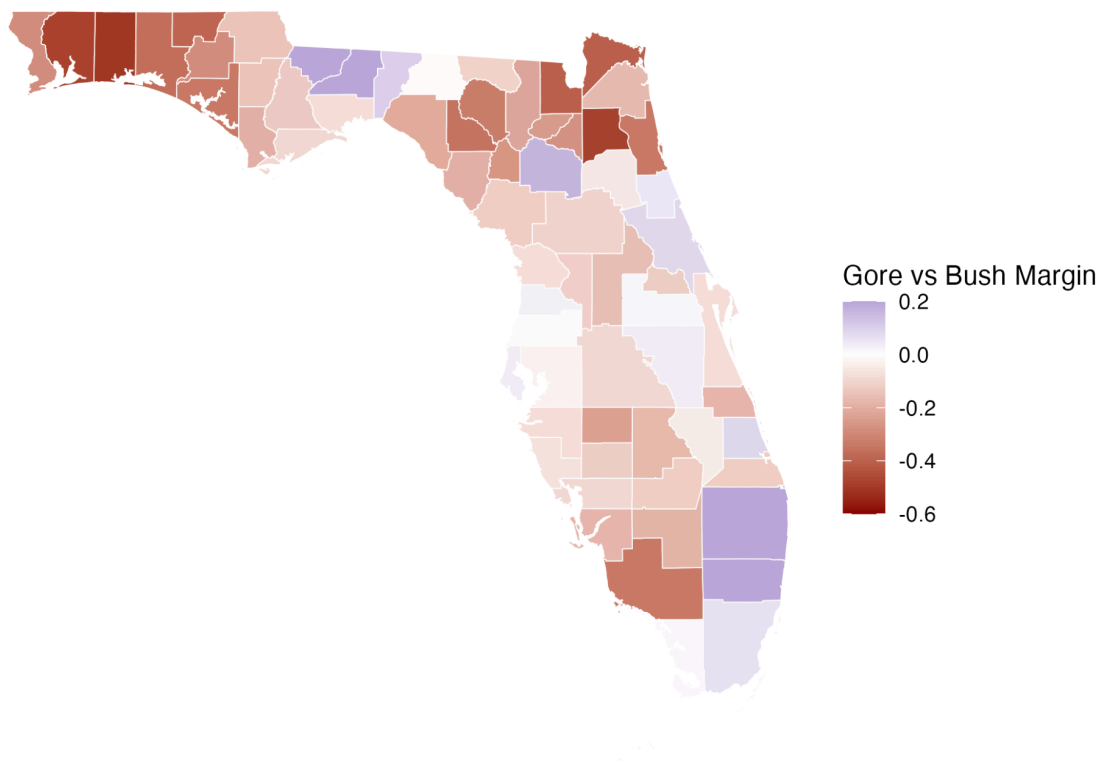


Figure 1

Internet and FaceBook Usage:

As the early 2000s approached, technological advancements created new opportunities for communication and connectivity. The internet saw a rise in usage between 2000 and 2008, as presented in the graph below. From 2000, the percentage of American adults who used the internet rose from 48% to 77% by 2008. In addition, social media, specifically Facebook, experienced an exponential increase in users from its inception in 2005 to 2008.

As the internet and social media grew, presidential candidates such as Ron Paul and Howard Dean used these platforms to advance their campaigns. Barack Obama is often credited with successfully using the internet and social media platforms to mobilize his supporters, run campaign ads, and collect digital donations, which led to his ultimate victory in 2008.

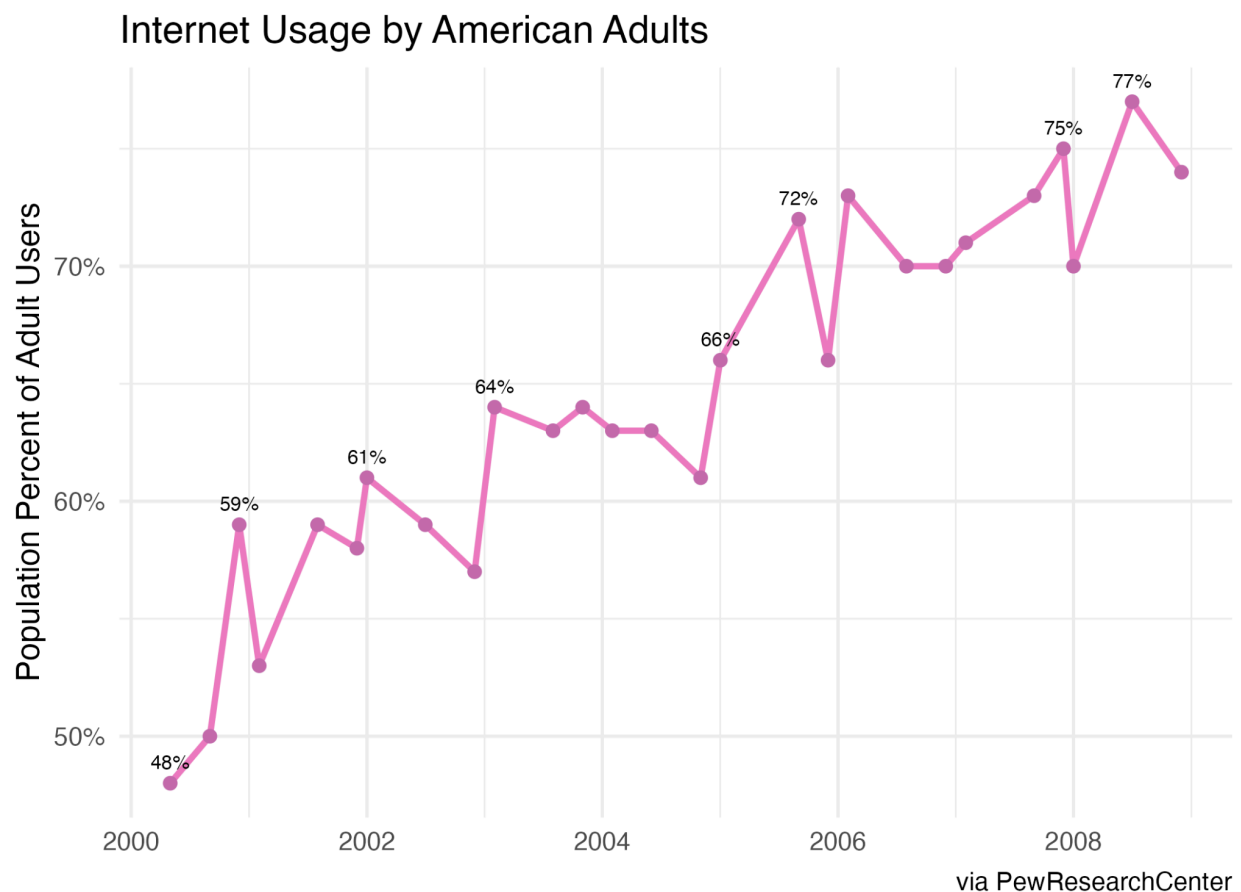


Figure 2

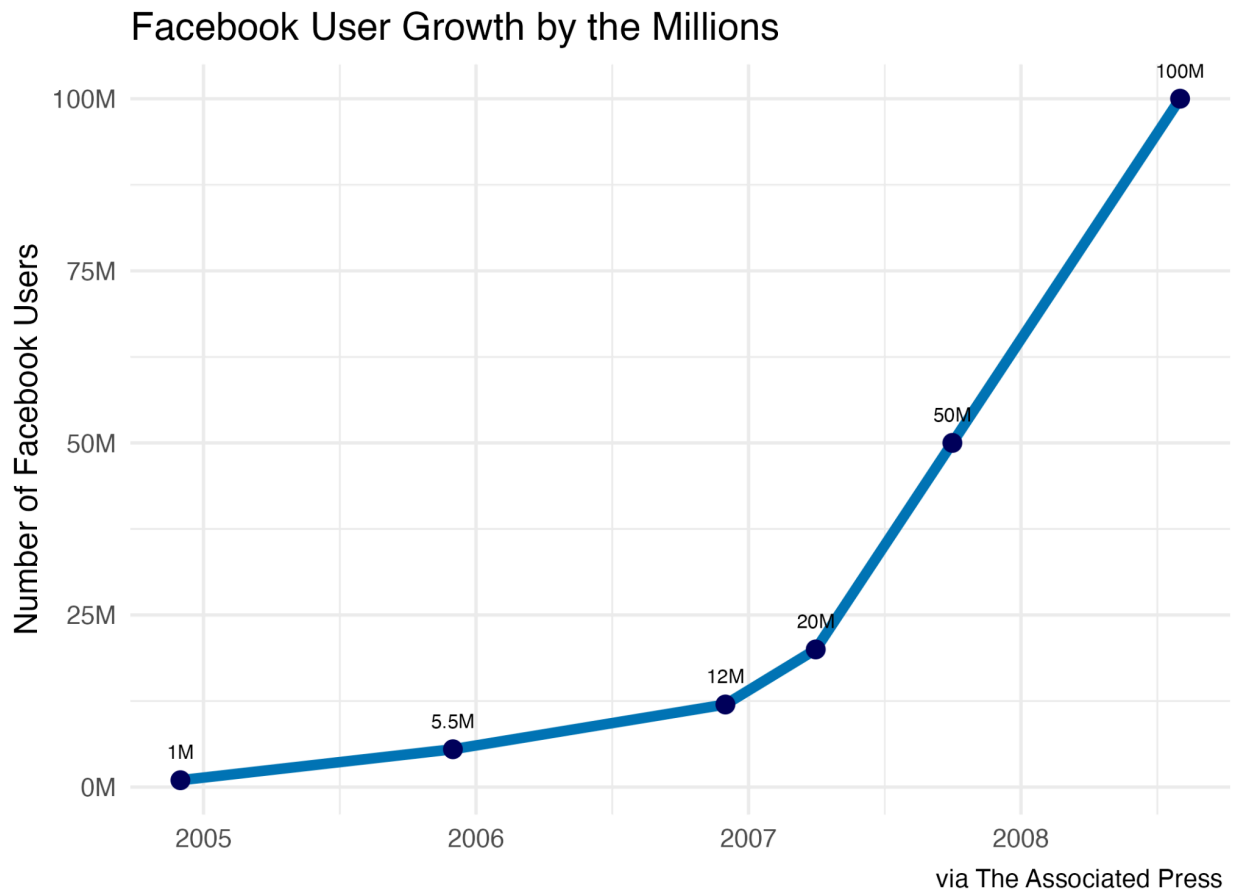


Figure 3 and “Barack Obama and the Facebook Election” via USNews.com

Youth Vote Share:

In presidential elections, candidates often target specific demographics to secure votes from the general public. As the 2000s progressed, the youngest voting age group, 18-29, has always aligned closely with the Democratic Party. As shown in the figure below, in the elections of 2000, 2004, and 2008, young voters' vote share always favored the Democratic nominee.

In 2008, Barack Obama won an overwhelming 66% of the youth vote share compared to John McCain's 32%. According to the Pew Research Center, this drastic increase in youth support for a Democratic candidate can be attributed to, "A wide 77%- majority of voters under age 30 disapprove of the U.S. war in Iraq, making them at least 15 points more negative on the war than older age groups"—an war initiated by previous Republican president George W. Bush. In addition, the Obama campaign had a greater reach to young supporters. The Pew Research Center states, "In North Carolina, for example, 46% of voters under age 30 reported being contacted by someone in the Obama campaign about coming out to vote, compared with 29% who reported being contacted by the McCain campaign."

Vote Share Among ages 18-29 by Candidate

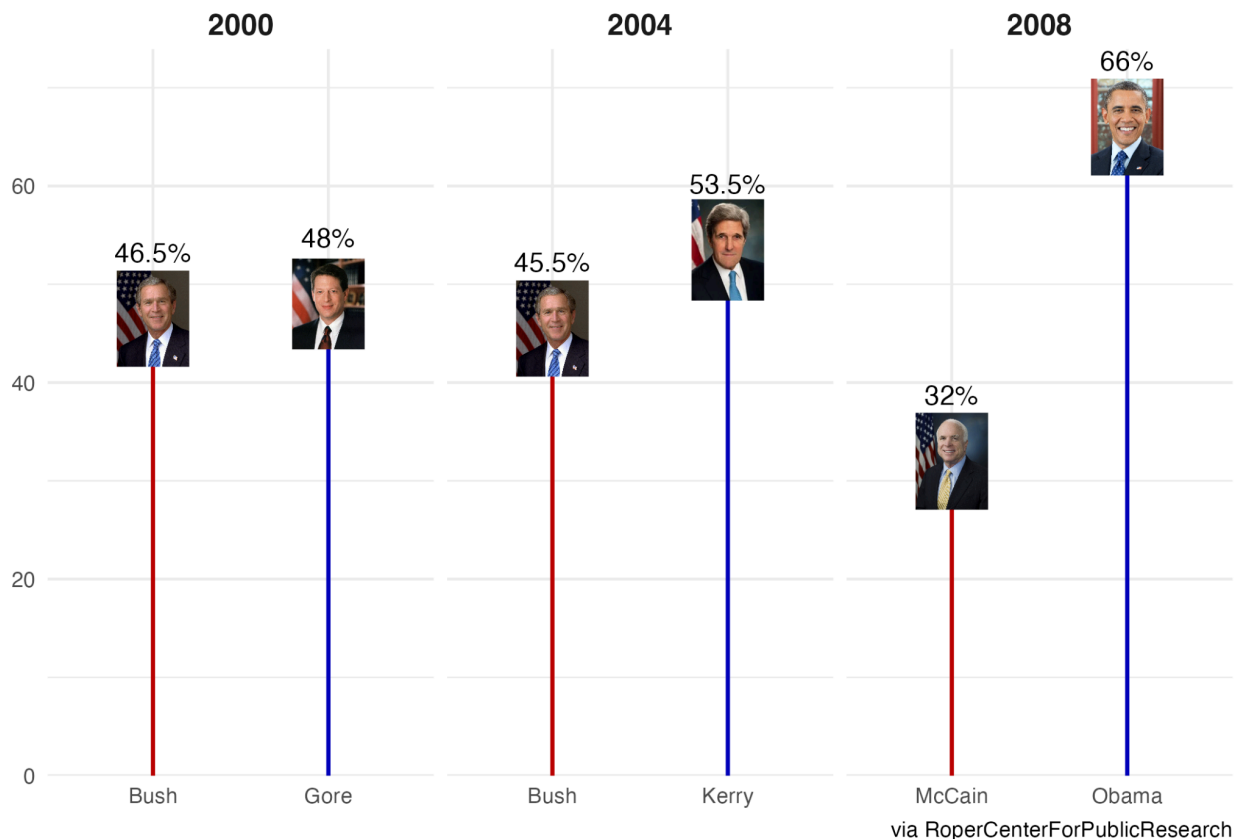


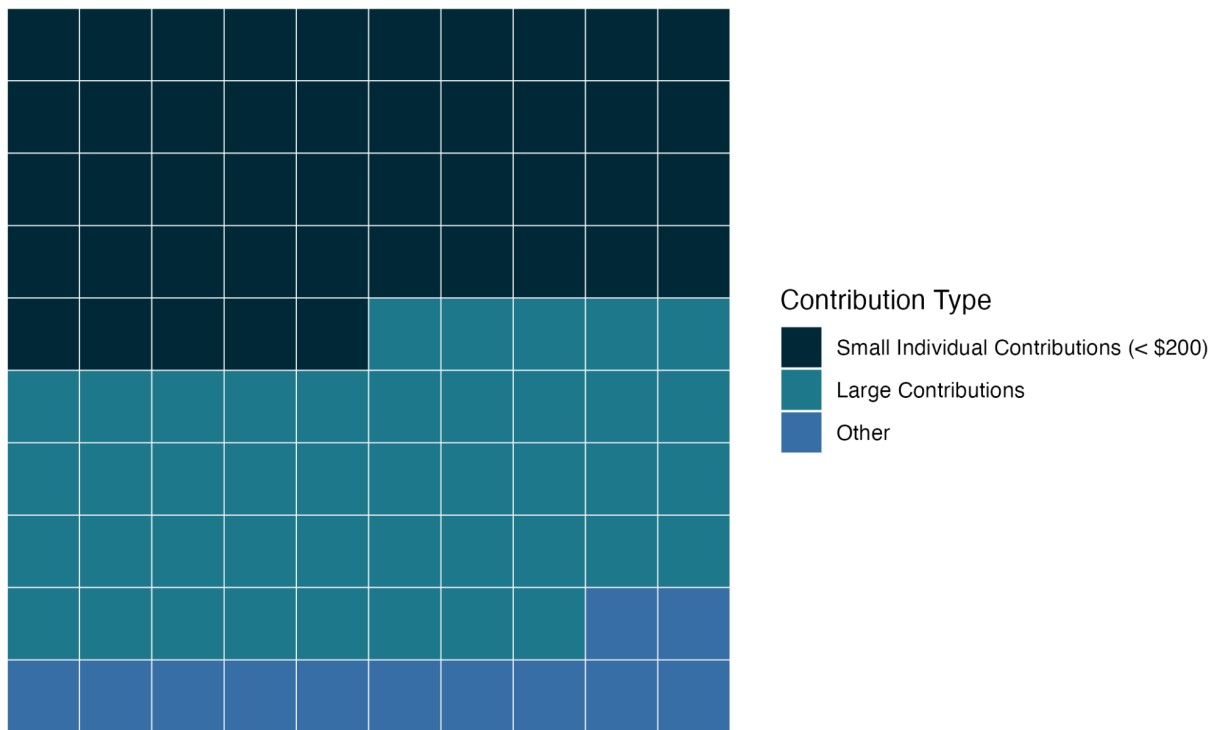
Figure 4

Small Donation Dominance:

It is often argued that money in elections holds great influence over candidates and potential victors. Prior to the 2010 decision in *FEC v. Citizens United* and the rise of Super PACs, the 2008 presidential election marked a shift in campaign contributions. As shown in the figure below, 49% of Barack Obama's campaign donations came from small donors, each donation being less than \$200. Each square in the chart below represents roughly 1% of Obama's total donations—equivalent to approximately \$7.45 million—throughout the 2008 presidential election, with a majority of the candidate's donations coming from small individual contributions. Despite the idea that “greater sums of donations lead to greater influence,” the Obama campaign demonstrated how smaller contributions can hold power in elections.

2008 Obama Campaign Contributions

Each square represents approximately 1% of total contributions (~\$7.45 million)



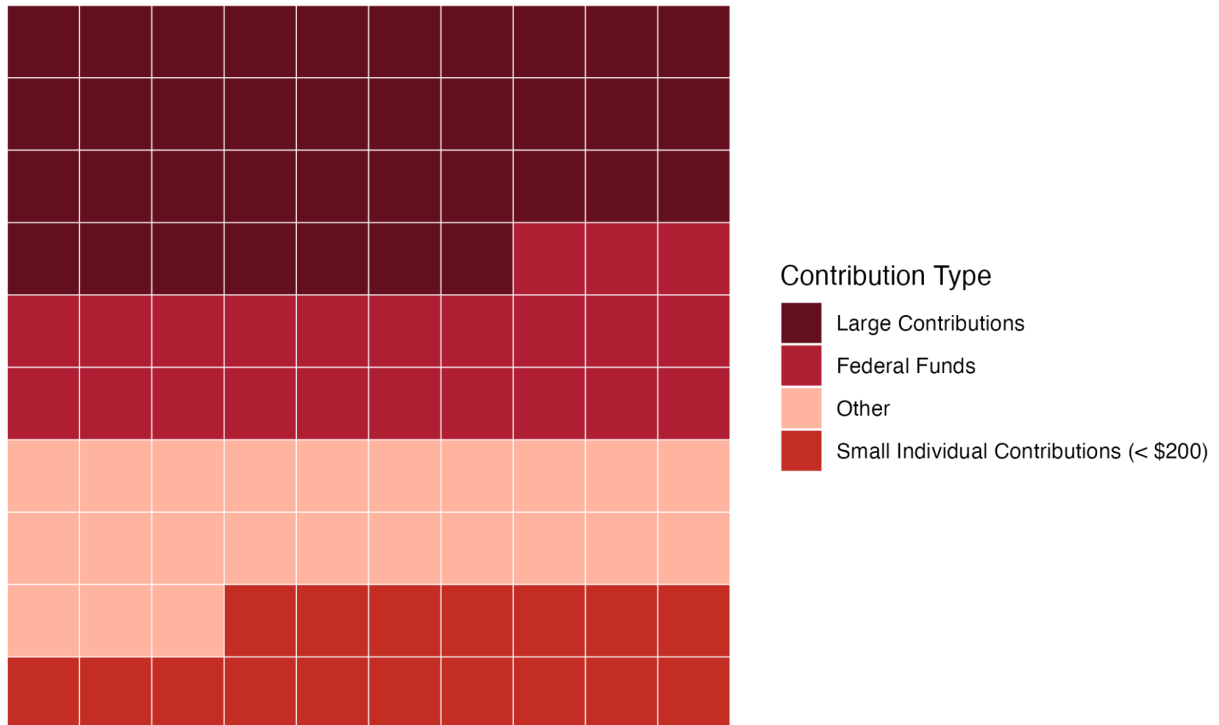
via OpenSecrets

Figure 5

This distribution can be directly compared to John McCain's financial contributions in the same election. In *Figure 6* below, each square represents approximately 1% of McCain's total contributions, which is roughly equivalent to \$3.67 million per square. McCain relied heavily on larger contributions, which took up 37% of his total distribution. McCain's contributions were made of up 17% small donations compared to Barack Obama's 49%.

2008 McCain Campaign Contributions

Each square represents approximately 1% of total contributions (~\$3.67 million)



via OpenSecrets

Figure 6

In addition, Obama simply held greater financial dominance in 2008. Obama raised more than twice as many campaign contributions as Senator McCain. *Figure 7* below shows. McCain's contributions are in closer relation to Obama's, clearly demonstrating this difference compared to *Figure 5*.

2008 McCain Campaign Contributions (In Close Relation to Obama)

Each square represents approximately 2% of total contributions (~\$7.33 million)

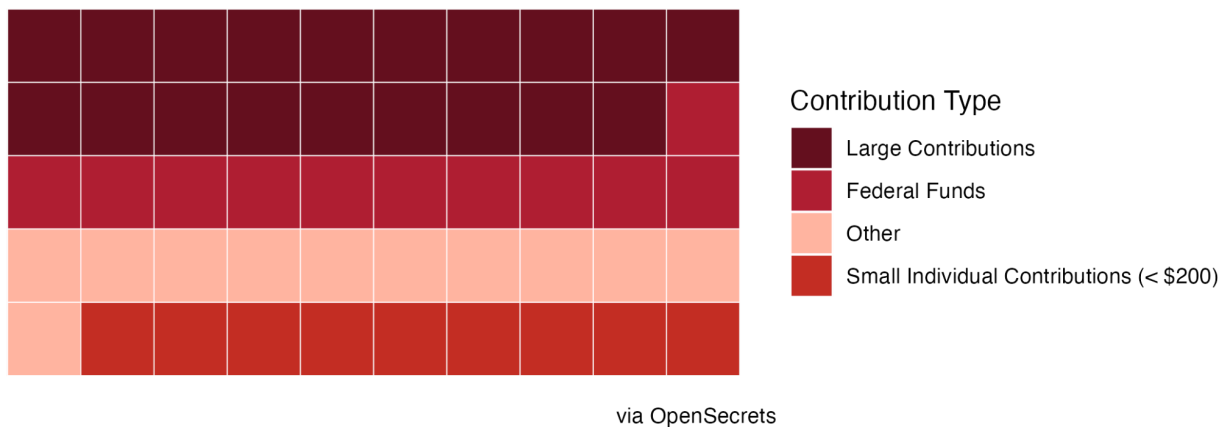


Figure 7

Conclusion:

Since 2000, American presidential elections have seen increases in internet usage, youth voter turnout for democratic candidates, and small donor contributions. In the 2000 election, the race had come down to the electoral votes in swing-state Florida. Fast forward to 2008, the eight-year transition in election culture and practices led to Barack Obama winning the East Coast state, becoming the first democratic candidate to receive the state's electoral votes in the new millennium.

2008 Election Voter Margins

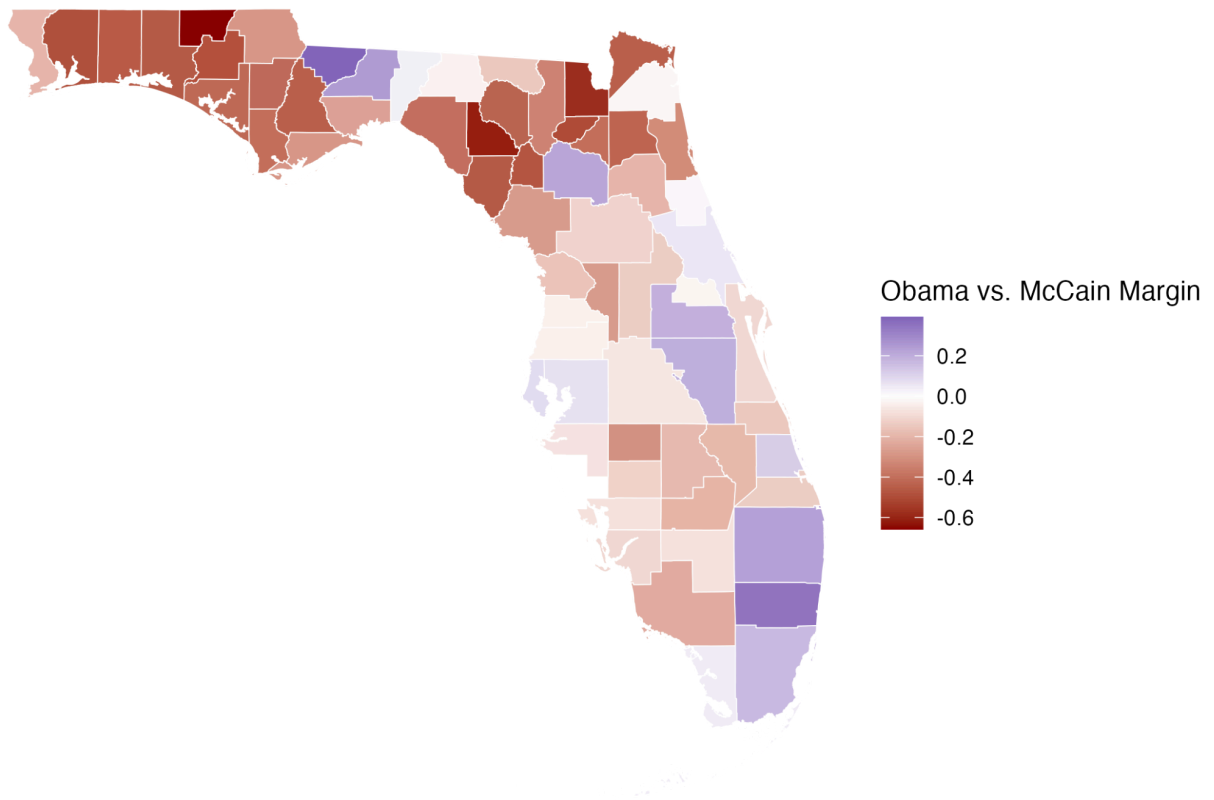


Figure 8